Gender and the Welfare State: Dividing Citizens

POSC 459 — Social Welfare Politics and Policy

Week 13 · Wednesday, November 18

Mettler 1998, Dividing Citizens, chs. 1, 5, 6



Poster: Social Security Board, 1936–37 · public domain

Today

1. From Monday to 1935
2. Mettler's question
3. Two kinds of citizenship
4. Building UI and ADC
5. Running them, 1936–1950
6. Mettler and Michener, side by side
7. Paper 5

From Monday to 1935

Michener: state discretion → racial gaps in the ACA

Mettler: the same choice in **1935**

What to run nationally? What to leave to the states?



Roosevelt signs the Social Security Act, Aug. 14, 1935 · FDR Library, CC BY 2.0

Michener 2020, pp. 550–51 · Mettler 1998, pp. 1–6

Mettler's question

Before 1935: citizenship "defined primarily by the individual states"

New Deal: Washington steps in, for some

Structured governance: policy design + administration → citizenship

Social citizenship: a claim to economic security as a member

Mettler 1998, pp. 1–5, 9 · figure 1, p. 5

Divided citizenship

	Liberal: included as individual wage earners	Nonliberal: included by role, relationship, or need
National: standard rules	**Old Age Insurance** **Fair Labor Standards Act** full-time wage earners: mostly white men	**Old Age and Survivors' Insurance (1939)** wives and widows, through husbands
State-level: variable, local discretion	**Unemployment Insurance*** a hybrid: national for most white men; state-level for women and nonwhite men	**Aid to Dependent Children** **Old Age Assistance** **protective labor laws** women and nonwhite men

Redrawn from Mettler, table 1, p. 23 · labels from pp. 5, 23–25

Who counted as a worker?





"Once again, agricultural and domestic workers were eliminated from coverage."

Servants on relief, 1934: more than **two-thirds** Black

Mettler, pp. 20, 26 n. 78, 136 · Photos: Russell Lee, Oklahoma, 1939; Marion Post Wolcott, Atlanta, 1939 · FSA/OWI, Library of Congress

Building unemployment insurance

- Perkins's committee: UI "the cornerstone"
- **3%** federal payroll tax; **90%** back to states with a law
- States set benefits and eligibility
- Built to replace "male breadwinners'" wages



Perkins, Jan. 22, 1935 · Harris & Ewing, LOC

Mettler, ch. 5, pp. 120–28, 136; ch. 6, p. 144

Building ADC

- Designed by two Children's Bureau women: Lenroot, Abbott
- State-run, ⅓ federal match
- Congress cut: "decency and health"
- **$18** first child, **$12** each other
- "no caretakers' benefits were included in ADC at all"



Federal Security Agency publicity print, 1940s · FSA/OWI, Library of Congress

Mettler, ch. 5, pp. 120, 129–40

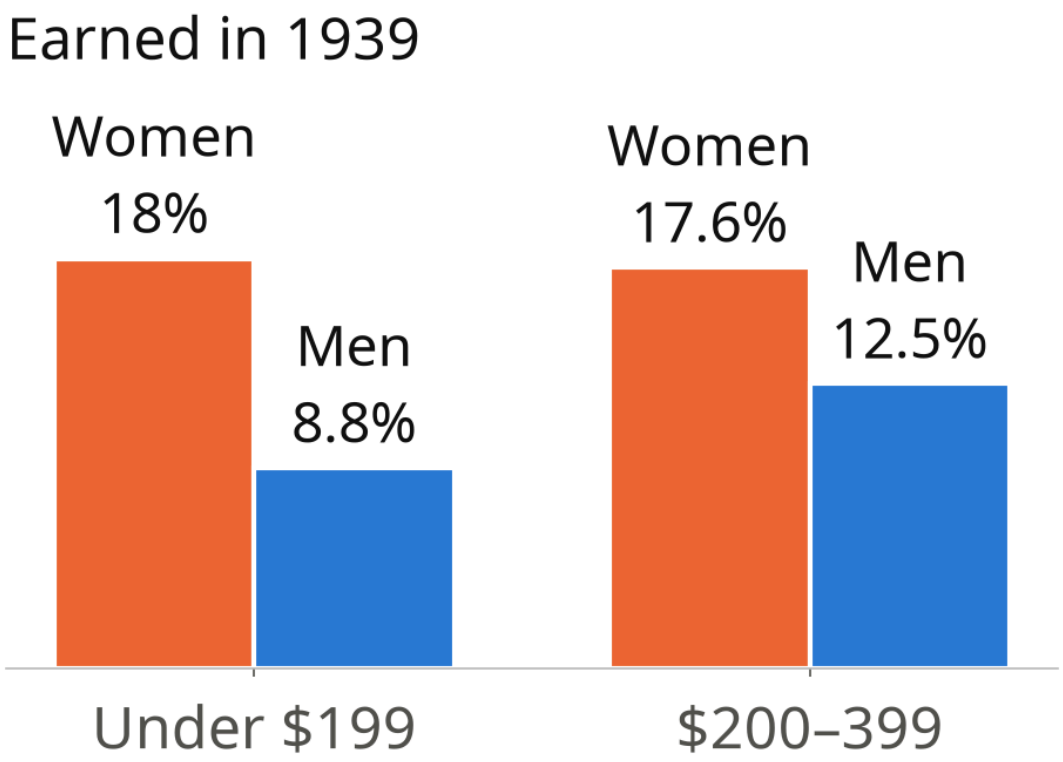
1935: "fairly comparable ground"

	UI	ADC
Run by	national and state	national and state
Eligibility set by	states	states
Merit system	no	no
Paid for by	employer tax, held in Washington	grants, **1 federal : 2 state**

Same start. What split them: money and administration.

Mettler, table 4, p. 142; pp. 141–43

UI in practice: who qualifies?



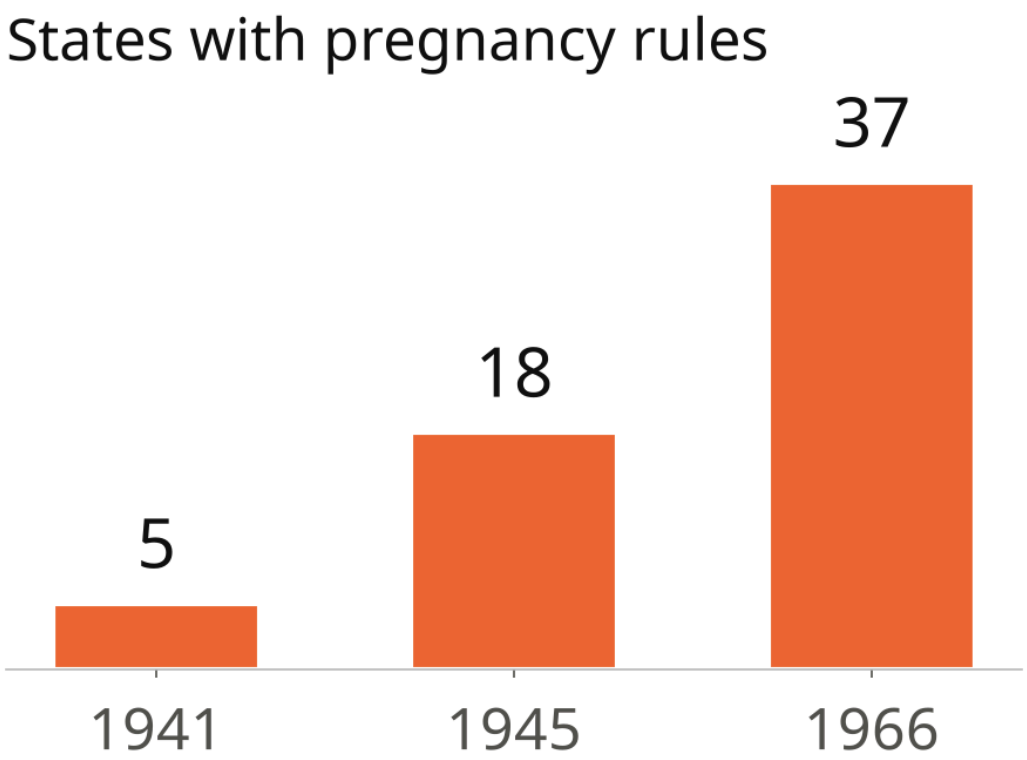
Earnings floors: **$100–300** a year (15 states, 1939)

"Available for work": full-time, daytime

"Domestic quits": no benefits

Mettler, ch. 6, pp. 150–53 · 1940 Census, cited

Pregnancy and marriage rules



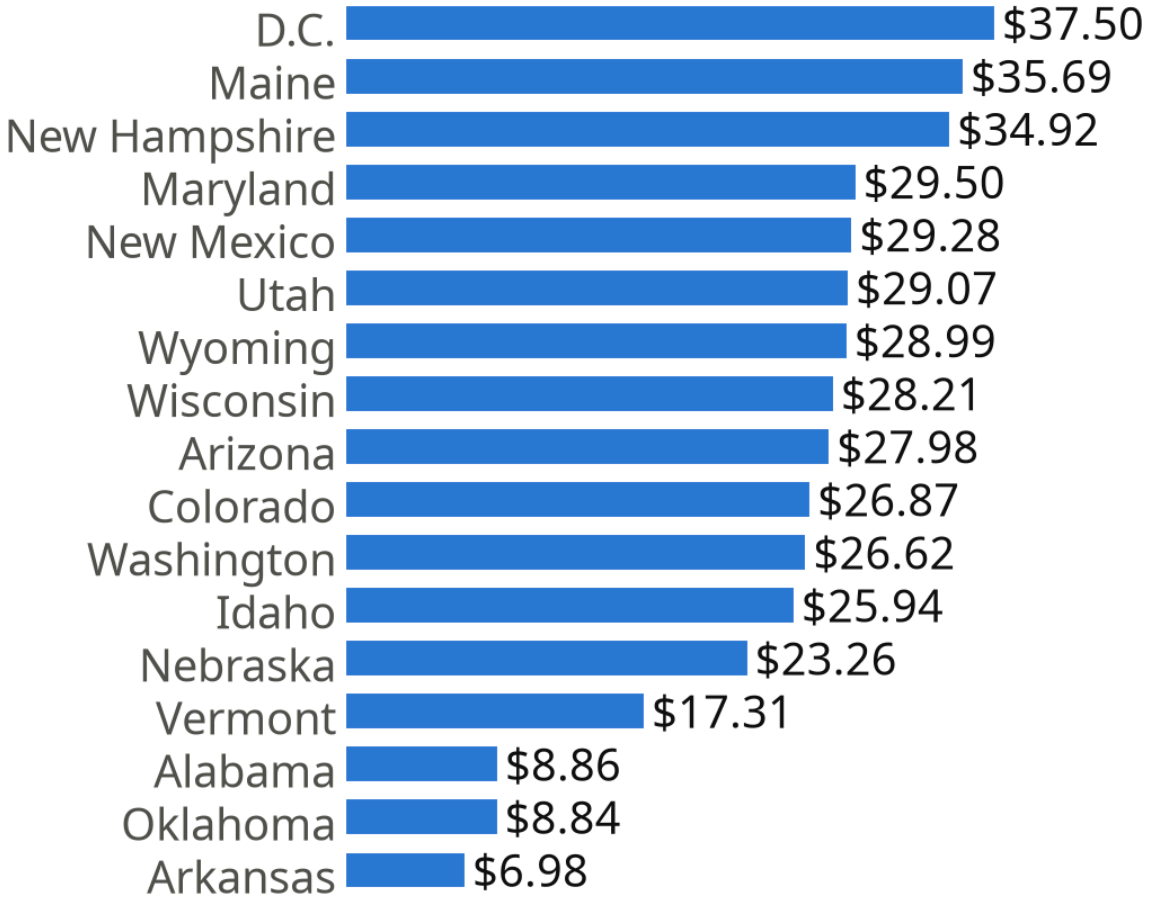
Pregnancy: disqualified or "unavailable"

Quit to marry: disqualified, **17** states by 1945

"UI acquired a janus-faced character"

Mettler, ch. 6, pp. 154–57, table 5

ADC in practice: the politics of place



1937: **$10.40** (Arkansas) to **$61.16** (Massachusetts)

"Suitable home" rules: **31** of 45 states, 1941

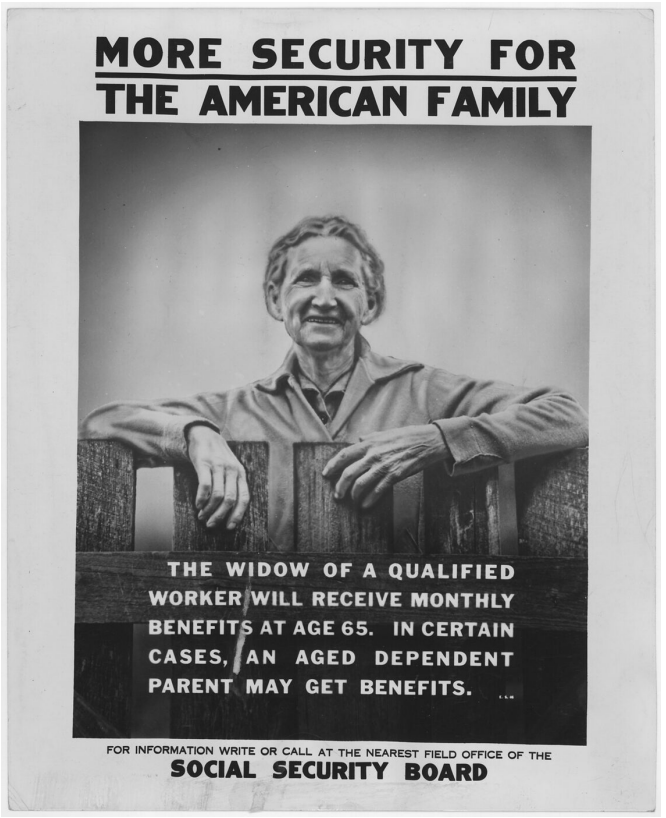
Georgia: a racial quota

Mettler, ch. 6, table 6, p. 160; pp. 164–72

1939: who moved up, who stayed

- Widows of covered workers → Social Security
- ADC: "inscribed with means testing"
- Black share of ADC families: **14–17%** late 1930s → **31%** in 1948

"rescued mostly white, middle-class women"



Social Security Board poster · FDR Library, National Archives

Mettler, ch. 6, pp. 167–69

Mettler's conclusion

"it was their designs that propelled them toward their separate fates"

UI: national uniformity · ADC: "vassals" of federalism

Mettler, ch. 6, p. 175

Mettler and Michener, side by side

	Mettler, 1935–1950	Michener, 2010–2020
Who is sorted	by gender, and race	by race, and place
Lever	program design, then administration	court ruling, state choice, waivers, appointees
State discretion	written in: eligibility, benefits, morals rules	opened by *Sebelius*; widened by waivers
Who lands in the state tier	women, nonwhite men	Black and Latino adults in the South
Her verdict	"their designs"	politics undoes policy

Same mechanism twice, or two that only look alike?

Mettler, pp. 5, 23, 175 · Michener, pp. 547, 550–55

Paper 5: draft your position

Pairs, 6 minutes

1. One mechanism or two? One sentence.
2. One page from Mettler, one from Michener
3. If one mechanism: where does it show up next?

Paper 5, due Fri 11/20, 11:59 p.m.

Paper 5, and next week

Fri 11/20, 11:59 p.m.: about 600 words

Position · pages from both · what it predicts

May use Howard ch. 9 and Gilens

11/23–27: Thanksgiving, no class

By 2:15 you should be able to say

Design + administration → kind of citizenship

National for white male earners; state-level for women, nonwhite men

Excluded: farm and domestic work

UI and ADC began alike; money and administration split them

ADC: low, variable, policed, and by 1948 Blacker

Mettler and Michener: one mechanism or two?